CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

BUTCHER IN THE AI ERA

The counter is real work and the door is wide open. It is also one of the highest-injury jobs in the BLS book, growing +2% in a decade, with a top decile barely above $51K.

★ TL;DR — NO. Butchers and Meat Cutters: median $40,140 (BLS, May 2025), growth +2% over the decade — just +3,300 jobs. A beginner starts toward the umbrella floor decile of $30,230; the grocery-counter industry median is $37,700 at all experience levels; the umbrella top decile is $51,730. BLS itself names the squeeze: cutting is centralising into pre-packaged production, which 'may limit employment growth for butchers and meat cutters'. AI does not take the counter — the counter is shrinking. The doors below use the same hands somewhere they appreciate. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

OUR TAKE: NO — NOT IN 2027

MEDIAN ~$40K · TRAINING 1-6 months · AI RISK LOW · CERTIFICATE

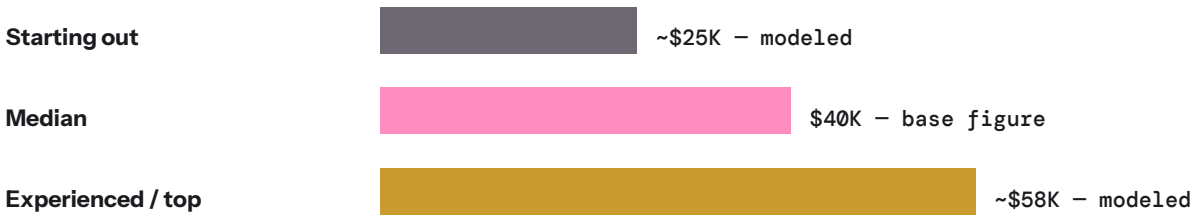
- Fails as a start because: +2% growth in ten years, a $40,140 median, and some of the highest injury and illness rates of all occupations (BLS) — cold rooms around 40°F, 50-lb lifts, knives and saws, for beginner pay toward $30,230.

- The structure is against the entry: half the group works in slaughtering and processing plants, where deployed automation (X-ray robotic lamb boning in production; Tyson's $1.3B automation programme) compresses the layer from the plant side.

- Honest counterweights: the door is open (no credential, employers train from simple cuts) and ~39,800 umbrella openings a year exist — ~97% of them replacement churn in a seat BLS says is being limited.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Butcher is a ~$40K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A BUTCHER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Cut, trim, grind and portion meat to order at a retail counter or in a plant
- ✓ Run saws, grinders and knives — and maintain them
- ✓ Weigh, wrap, price and display; advise customers on cuts and cooking
- ✓ Hold sanitation and food-safety standards in a cold room, all shift

Think: a skilled trade performed inside a refrigerator, with the factory version of your job automating down the road.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
Plant-level and real: Scott Technology's X-ray-guided automated lamb boning rooms are in full production (one installation 'replaces five bandsaws'); Tyson announced $1.3B+ in automation and AI investment from 2022. Beef automation is still pre-production demonstration. The retail counter seat itself is not performed by AI — BLS notes deboning 'is not easily automated'.	Counter judgment: reading a carcass or a customer's vague description and producing the right cut, special orders, display craft, and the trust of regulars who buy from a person.

⚠ **BLS's sentence belongs on this card unsoftened: butchers and meat cutters 'have some of the highest rates of injuries and illnesses of all occupations.' Add extended time in rooms around 40°F and routine lifts over 50 pounds. Price that into any 'honest trade' pitch — the corrected $40K median buys it.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT

✓ No credential gate: hired and trained on the job, starting from simple cuts ✓ Knife skill is genuinely portable — into catering, kitchens and food businesses ✓ Steady replacement demand: the work does not vanish, it just does not grow	✗ +2% growth in a decade and a $51,730 umbrella top decile ✗ Injury rates among the highest in the BLS book; cold, wet, heavy work ✗ Pre-packaged central production is shrinking the very counter seat you'd enter

Good fit? You want food work with your hands and a fast exit plan — the knife skills are the asset, not the counter.
Bad fit? You were sold a growing heritage trade with a craftsman's pay ladder. The BLS numbers describe neither.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — PIVOT TO Caterer	DOOR B — PIVOT TO Restaurant Manager
Catering monetises exactly what a butcher knows — proteins, portions, costing per head — at event prices instead of retail margins. Beginners are hired into catering work immediately, and a permitted own business is legally openable in year one (food-facility permit plus commissary agreement; see the Caterer roadmap). Labelled anchor: Food Service Managers $69,390 (BLS, May 2025), +6%, ~38,800 openings a year. First move: build one priced protein-centred event menu and cost it to the ounce.	Food Service Managers: median $69,390, +6%, ~38,800 openings a year, formal requirement a high school diploma plus less than 5 years of related experience, ladder printed (floor ~$35K → supervisor $45,370 → manager $69,390). Meat knowledge is a genuine edge in food-cost management — protein is the biggest line on the P&L; you'll be hired to control. First move: take a lead role in your current operation and own the protein cost number for a quarter.

Smart move: Sell costing, not cutting. Anyone can hire hands for a saw; the worker who knows what a primal should yield, and what waste is costing, is quoting manager-level value.
Where you land after: You land where protein knowledge prices at event or P&L; rates — the $69K anchor — instead of a $40K counter with a $52K ceiling.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
READ THE	ENTER FOR	PICK YOUR	BUILD THE	PROTECT THE	STEP OFF

STEP 1 — Read the real numbers

FREE · TODAY

- Read the BLS Meat, Poultry, and Fish Processing Workers page: $40,140 butcher median, +2% growth, the injury-rates section
- Find BLS's own warning: pre-packaged production 'may limit employment growth for butchers and meat cutters'

STEP 2 — Enter for the skills, with an exit date

WEEKS 1-4

- If you take a counter or plant seat, choose the employer that teaches whole-animal and costing skills, not just portioning
- Get the food handler's certification your state requires — hours, often within weeks of hire

STEP 3 — Pick your door

MONTH 2

- Door A if you want your own book: catering events priced per head
- Door B if you want the salaried climb: food-cost ownership toward the manager seat

STEP 4 — Build the costing proof

MONTHS 2-6

- Keep a yield book: primal in, sellable cuts out, waste priced — your numbers, from your hands
- Price one full event menu to the ounce (Door A) or present one quarter of protein-cost savings (Door B)

STEP 5 — Protect the asset — you

ONGOING

- Cut-resistant gloves, aprons, nonslip footwear, knife discipline — the injury statistics are occupational, not personal, until they are
- Rotate heavy and cold exposure where you can; a ruined back ends every door on this page

STEP 6 — Step off the counter on schedule

YEAR 1

- By month 12: a catering book started, or a lead/supervisor title held — not just seniority at the block
- The counter will still be there. That is precisely the problem with staying

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: read the BLS butcher page — median, growth, and the injuries section, all of it.
- □ Days 1–30: employed cutting (or applications out); door chosen; yield book started.
- □ Days 31–60: costing proof in progress; food handler's card done where required.
- □ Days 61–90: one priced event menu or one owned cost number to show for the quarter.
- □ Day 90: your knife skills are priced as knowledge, not rented by the hour in a cold room.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test

· Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ KNOW THE YIELD. LEAVE THE BLOCK. ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.